





the basic  
idea

does free  
will explain  
any evil?

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free  
will explain  
all evil?

1. The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami is an evil.
  2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.
  3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
  4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1,2,3)
  5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.
- 

C. God does not exist. (4,5)

The argument from natural evil

Let's consider two replies to this objection.

The first is due to the  
contemporary philosopher Marilyn  
Adams.





“Human radical vulnerability to horrors cannot have its origin in misused created freedom, because – even if one accepted the story of Adam’s fall as historical ... the way it is told, humans were radically vulnerable to horrors from the beginning, even in Eden.

The framework within which the primal ancestors made their choices was such that obedient choices meant persistence of the status quo, while disobedient choices would result in the horrendous disarray such as humans have experienced ever since. ... [T]he

fact that the consequences amplify far beyond their capacity to conceive and hence to intend ... is not something for which

humans are responsible. Rather it is a function of the interaction between human agency and the wider framework within which it is set, and God is responsible for creating human beings in such a framework!”



4. There is no moment and perfectly good being. (1, 2, 3)

2 There is no good which outweighs this event and which is

does not exist.

such that an infant being fed not have brought

impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without



3. Absolutely good being would eliminate every evil

eliminating the good.

The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami is avail.

there was a good weight and it was

5 If there is no merit and perfectly good being, God

c. God does not exist. (4,5)



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Adams.

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contemporary philosophy Marilyn



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'Humanitarian' horrors

can't have it's original created

story of Adam's fall as his story and the way



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to her from the beginning, even in Eden.

result in the hereditary disease such as



**Free will  
cannot  
explain any  
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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any evil?

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**does free  
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God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

there are possible  
situations which an  
omnipotent  
being cannot  
bring about





we have  
free will



free will is  
a great good

the ability  
to harm others  
is a great good



the basic  
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“Traditional free-will approaches - with their move to shift responsibility and/or blame for evil away from God and onto personal creatures - are stalemated by horrendous evil. Human radical vulnerability to horrors cannot have its origin in misused created freedom, because - even if one accepted the story of Adam’s fall as historical (which I do not) - the way it is told, humans were radically vulnerable to horrors from the beginning, even in Eden. The framework within which the primal ancestors made their choices was such that obedient choices meant persistence of the status quo, while disobedient choices would result in the horrendous disarray such as humans have experienced ever since. Even if Adam’s and Eve’s choices are supposed to be somehow self-determined, the fact that the consequences amplify far beyond their capacity to conceive and hence to intend - viz., to horrors of which ex hypothesi they had no prior experience and of which they could therefore have no adequate conception - is not something for which humans are responsible. Rather it is a function of the interaction between human agency and the wider framework within which it is set, and God is responsible for creating human beings in such a framework!”